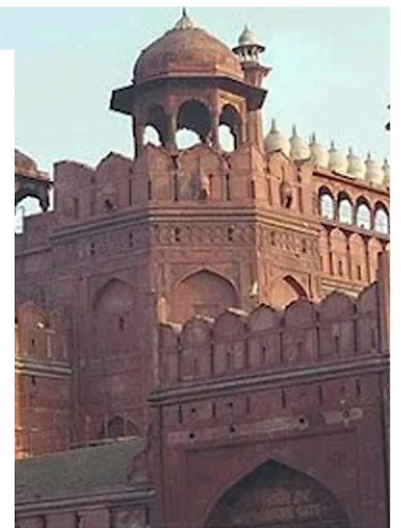
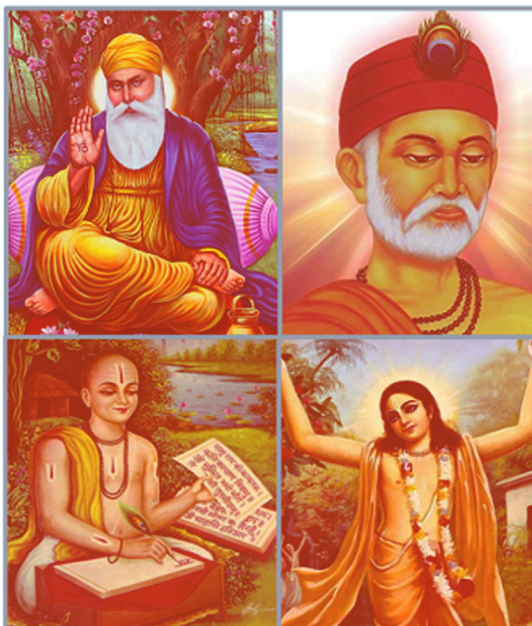
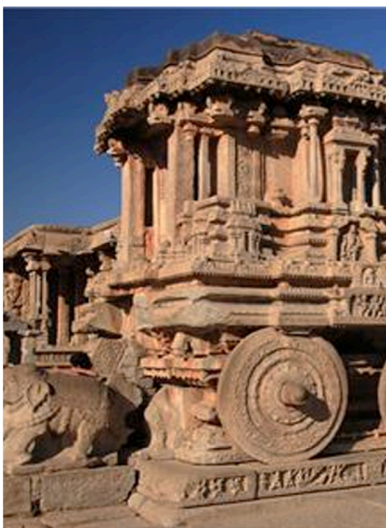


General Knowledge

Medieval History

STUDY NOTES

Imperial Cholas



Imperial Cholas



Imperial Cholas

Administration Under Cholas

- Parantaka I Chola of 919 A.D. and 921 A.D. may be said to constitute a **great landmark in the history of the Chola village assemblies. It marks one of the world's earliest pieces of evidence of Local self-government**
- It gives details about the functioning and constitution of the local sabha.
- There were 30 wards (**kudumbus**) each nominating members for selections of people with the prescribed qualifications.
- Elections from each ward were by lot (**kudavolai**, literally means pot-ticket) for one year.
- Of the thirty so selected, twelve members who had earlier served in the garden and tank committee and were advanced in age were assigned to the **samvatsarvariya**m or annual committee, twelve to the **Tottavariya**m or the **garden committee** and
- 6 members of the **Eri-variya**m or **tank committee Pancha-variya**m (**a standing committee**) and **Pon-variya**m (**gold committee**) were the other two committees.
- **Variyapparumakal** were the members of the committee,
- **Perunguri** were the members of the Mahasabha;
- **Nyayaffarwas** the Judicial committee and Madhyasthas, a small staff of paid servants in the village assisted the committees and maintained village records.

Functions of Local Administration

- The Assembly generally met in the temple, or under a tree or near a tank
- The sabha possessed proprietary rights over communal lands.
- It also **controlled the private lands** of the villages.
- It reclaimed **forest and wasteland**. It aided in the assessment of the produce and land revenue.
- It collected land revenue and had the power to sell the land in question, in cases of default.
- It also had the powers of taxation for purposes connected with the village and of remission of taxation for specific reasons.
- The village was the basic unit of administration during Chola Period.
- The villages were broadly of three types.

Ur/Kurrams

- The first type constituted an **intercaste population** where the land was held by all classes of people
- The people paid taxes to the king in the form of **land revenue**.
- It was the most frequent type.

Brahmadana

- This was the second type, the Brahmadana/Brahmadeya or agrahara villages which **were granted to the Brahmins**
- The village was entirely inhabited by them.
- They were **exempted from tax** and **were prosperous**.

Devadana

- The third type of village was the Devadana, which were **villages granted to god**.
- The **revenues from these villages were donated to a temple**.
- During Cholas, the Devadana type of villages gained more popularity as the temples became the centres of life.

Important Chola Rulers

Rajendra Chola (1014-1044AD)

- Rajendra I, son of Rajaraja succeeded him and came to the throne in 1014 A.D.
- He ruled jointly with his father for a few years.
- He also followed a **policy of conquest and annexation** adopted by his father and further raised the power and prestige of the Cholas.
- He followed the expansionist policy and made extensive conquests in Ceylon.
- The Pandya and Kerala country after being conquered was constituted as a viceroyalty under the Chola king with the title of Chola-Pandya.
- Madurai was its headquarters.
- Proceeding through Kalinga, Rajendra I attacked Bengal and defeated the Pala ruler Mahipala in 1022 A.D. But he annexed no territory in north India.
- To commemorate the occasion, **Rajendra I assumed the title of Gangaikondachola (the Chola conqueror of Ganga).**
- He built the new capital near the mouth of the Kaveri and **called it Gangaikondacholapuram** (the city of the Chola conqueror of the Ganga).
- With his naval forces, he invaded the Malaya Peninsula and the Srivijaya Empire that extended over Sumatra, Java and the neighbouring islands and controlled the overseas trade route to China.
- He sent two diplomatic missions to China for political as well as commercial purposes.

Rajaraja Chola (985-1014AD)

- The **original name, Arumolivarman**, who crowned himself as Rajaraja I in 985 A D the next thirty years of his rule formed the formative period of Chola imperialism.
- He was the successor of Parantaka II,
- The Chola kingdom grew under him into an extensive and well-knit empire, efficiently organized and administered and possessing a powerful standing army and navy.
- Rajaraja began his conquests by attacking the confederation between the rulers of the Pandya and Kerala kingdoms and of Ceylon.
- Polonnaruwa became the capital of Chola province in North Ceylon after the defeat of Mahinda V, the Ceylonese king.
- He also annexed the Maldives. Elsewhere, several parts of modern Mysore were conquered and annexed which intensified their rivalry with the Chalukyas.

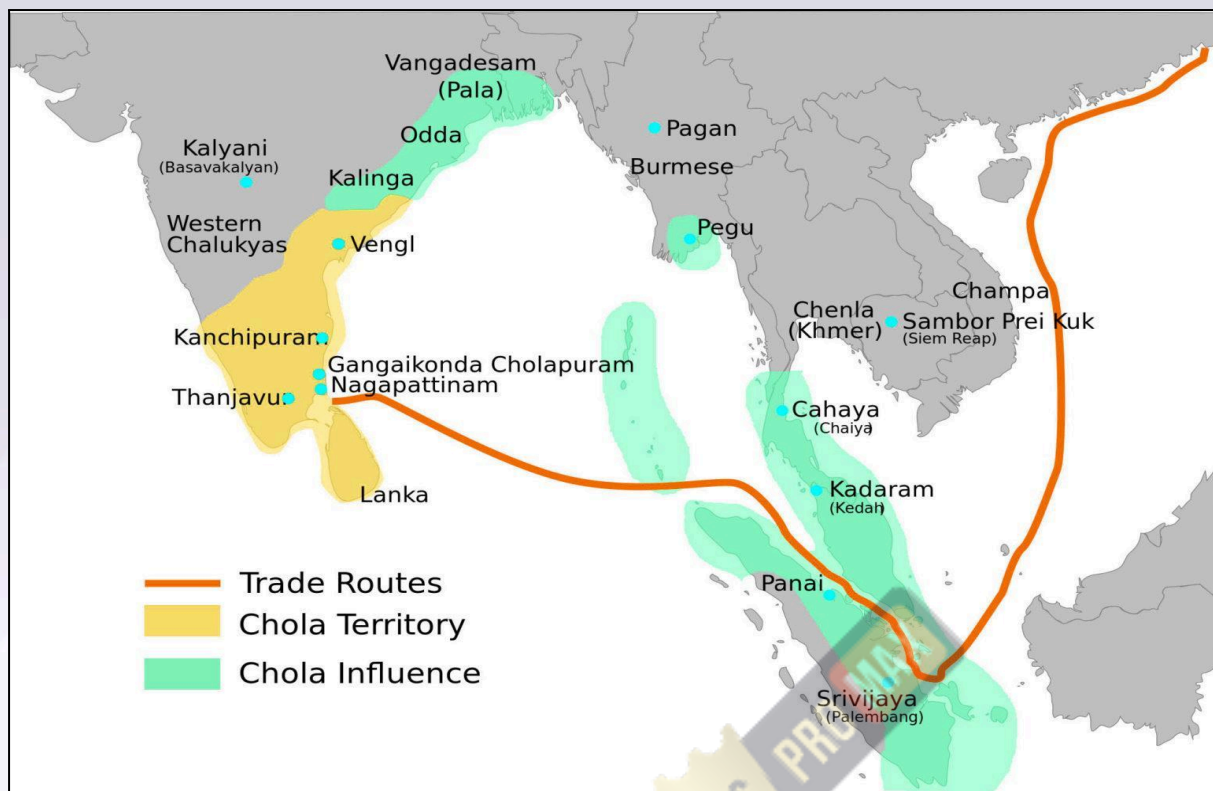
- Rajaraja built the magnificent Shiva temple of Brihadeshwara or Rajaraja temple at Thanjavur which was completed in 1010.
- It is considered a remarkable piece of architecture in the South Indian style.
- Rajaraja I also encouraged Sri Mara Vijayottungavarman, the Sailendra ruler of Sri Vijaya to build a Buddhist Vihara at Negapatam.
- This vihara was called '**Chudamani Vihara**' after the father of Sri Mara.

Virarajendra Chola

- Virarajendra I, too defeated the Chalukyas and erected a pillar of victory on the banks of Tungabhadra.
- Virarajendra died in 1070 A.D.

Kulottunga Chola (1070-1122 AD)

- He was succeeded by Kulottunga I (1070-1122 A.D.) the great-grandson of Rajaraja I. He was the son of Rajendra Narendra of Vengi and Chola princess Ammangadevi (daughter of Rajendra Chola I).
- Thus Kulottunga I **united the two kingdoms of the Eastern Chalukyas of Vengi and the Cholas of Thanjavur.**
- The most important reform carried out by him in the internal administration was the re- survey of land for taxation and revenue purposes.
- He was also titled Sungam tavirtta (he who abolished tolls).
- The Chola authority in Ceylon was overthrown by Vijayababu, the monarch of Ceylon during Kulottunga's reign.
- He sent a **large embassy of 72 merchants to China and also maintained cordial relations with Sri Vijaya.**
- He defeated the rulers of the Pandya kingdom and that of Kerala.
- The Chola Empire continued for more than a century after him.



Art and Architecture Under Cholas

Virasoliyam

- Virasoliyam was a famous **grammatical work in Tamil**,
- It was **written by Buddhmitra during the reign of Virarajendra Chola**
- Buddhmitra was a writer and poet who was patronaged by the Chola King, Virarajendra.
- He tried to bring synthesis to the grammar written in Tamil by bringing it closer to Sanskrit.
- Chola rulers promoted cultural richness by giving special attention to literature and architecture.
- The book was written by **Buddhamitra who followed Buddhism**.
- The book was being written by their co-religious follower so it was widely studied in the colleges run on the Buddhist line.

Chola temples

- The Great Living Chola Temples (recognised by UNESCO) were built by kings of the Chola Empire, which stretched over all of south India and the neighbouring islands.
- The site includes three great 11th- and 12th-century Temples:

1. **the Brihadisvara Temple at Thanjavur,**
 2. **the Brihadisvara Temple at Gangaikondacholisvaram and**
 3. **the Airavatesvara Temple at Darasuram.**
- **Brihadisvara Temple, Gangaikondacholisvaram**
 - The Temple of **Gangaikondacholisvaram, built by Rajendra I, was completed in 1035.**
 - Its **53-m vimana** (sanctum tower) has recessed corners and a graceful upward-curving movement, contrasting with the straight and severe tower at Thanjavur.
 - **The Airavatesvara temple, Darasuram**
 - The Airavatesvara temple complex, built by Rajaraja II, at Darasuram, features a **24-m vimana** and a stone image of Shiva.
 - The temples testify to the brilliant achievements of the Chola in architecture, sculpture, painting and bronze casting.
 - In the 12th Century, King Rajaraja Chola II built the Airavatesvara Temple at Darasuram.
 - The temple comprises a '**mandapa**' (entrance porch) **made in the style of a ratha, or chariot with wheels.**
 - The **concept was later expanded in the Sun Temple of Konark**, of the 13th century.
 - **The Brihadisvara Temple, Thanjavur**
 - The Brihadisvara temple at Thanjavur marks the greatest achievement of the Chola architects. Known in the inscriptions as Dakshina Meru, the construction of this temple was inaugurated by the Chola King, Rajaraja I (985-1012 CE) and consecrated by his own hands in (1009-1010 CE).
 - A massive collonaded prakara with sub-shrines dedicated to the ashatadikpalas and the main entrance with gopura (known as Rajarajantiruvasal) encompasses the massive temple.
 - The sanctum itself occupies the centre of the rear half of the rectangular court.
 - The vimana soars to a height of **59.82 meters over the ground.**
 - There is a circumambulatory path all around the sanctum housing a **massive linga.**
 - **The temple walls are embellished with expansive and exquisite mural paintings**

Early Chola Temples

- **Vijayalaya Cholisvara Temple:**

- Vijayalaya Cholisvara temple is located at Narthamalai.
- This Temple was built by Vijayalaya Chola or by the Muttaraya chieftains before his rule.
- The temple, dedicated to Shiva, faces west.
- **Features**-One of the hands of Lord Shiva displays the gesture of *vismaya* or *wonder*.

- **Brahmapurisvara temple:**

- This temple is located at Pullamangai.
- The temple presents a tradition that develops further in later Chola temples.
- The **deities are carved in niches on the walls and attendant figures are made in adjoining niches.**
- Every part of the temple **wall has dressed stones.**
- A favourite motif in Indian art, from north to south, is seen here: **a human figure riding on a vyala or leograph.**